

**THE UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG
FACULTY OF BUSINESS AND ECONOMICS**

**Master of Global Management
PMGM7022 Strategy in the Digital World**

I. GENERAL INFORMATION

Instructor: Dr. Jiang BIAN
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Office: KKL 1127
Phone: 3917-0027
Office Hours: Thursday 11:00am – 12:00noon
Teaching Assistant: Section AB: Olivia LI, kongqili@hku.hk

Class Time: Section A: Sat 9:30am – 12:30pm; 2:00pm – 5:00pm (CP-LTA)
Section B: Sun 9:30am – 12:30pm; 2:00pm – 5:00pm (CP-LTA)

Class Materials: Readings, cases, and study questions will be posted on Moodle.

II. COURSE DESCRIPTION

This course aims to equip students with a strong conceptual foundation for understanding the digital revolution and the emerging artificial intelligence (AI) transformation in the global business environment. As digitization and AI reshape the nature of business across a wide range of industries, mastering the concepts and practices of digital and AI-driven innovation is crucial for managers, entrepreneurs, and investors. Moreover, a global perspective is becoming ever more critical as digital technologies and platforms change both the speed and the reach for businesses to access new ideas and resources, provide their products and services, enter new markets, and navigate through both traditional partnerships and newly-emerged ecosystems.

This course examines a variety of topics related to digital transformation including how platform business models create and capture value, how network effects drive competitive dynamics, and how new technologies including generative AI are creating new strategic opportunities and threats across the digital ecosystem. The course is theory- and research-based but practice-oriented. Through disciplined analyses of successful and unsuccessful cases across industry and national borders, this course will provide students with the sophistication to identify, evaluate, and act upon new business opportunities successfully in a truly global and digital world.

Who Should Take This Course?

Strategy in the Digital World is a course targeted towards students who plan to become involved with technology-based and AI-driven companies across industries either right after graduation or

at some future point in their careers. Since the course emphasizes how digital technologies disrupt conventional ways of doing business and enable new business models, it is meant to help students evaluate, analyze, and capture digital-age opportunities in their capacity as:

- Founders of or early hires in technology and AI ventures
- Investors in, or advisors to digital platforms and incumbent firms
- Potential partners or acquirers of digital ventures
- Managers in large, established companies pursuing digital transformation or AI integration
- Product managers and strategists navigating platform ecosystems and AI-enhanced products

III. COURSE OBJECTIVES

1. To introduce the theoretical concepts pertaining to digital economy, platform business models, and open innovation
2. To understand the basic characteristics of digital platforms and marketplaces, and their implications on strategy and competitive dynamics
3. To analyze how AI, particularly generative AI, is transforming platform strategy, creating new business models, and disrupting established competitive positions
4. To understand the opportunities and challenges in adopting digitally enhanced or led business models across industry and national boundaries
5. To develop the professional competencies of identifying, analyzing and executing digital opportunities for value creation and value capture

IV. PROGRAM LEARNING GOALS (PLOS)

PLO1: Acquisition and internalization of knowledge of the program discipline

PLO2: Application and integration of knowledge

PLO3: Inculcating professionalism and leadership

PLO4: Developing global outlook

PLO5: Mastering communication skills

V. COURSE LEARNING OUTCOMES (CLOS)

Course Learning Outcomes	Aligned Program Learning Outcome
CLO1: Develop a solid grounding in the key concepts pertaining to digital economy, open innovation, and platform business models.	PLO1
CLO2: Obtain an in-depth understanding of the current issues and emerging trends of platform businesses as well as their impact on business strategy and the broader society.	PLO2, 3, 4
CLO3: Apply learned frameworks and tools in identifying, evaluating and capturing digitally enabled business opportunities, and leading digital transformation in an increasingly global context.	PLO1, 2, 3, 4

Course Learning Outcomes	Aligned Program Learning Outcome
CLO4: Demonstrate effective digital leadership and develop strategic recommendations for companies navigating fast-evolving digital technologies and platform ecosystems.	PLO2, PLO3
CLO5: Communicate strategic analyses and recommendations effectively through written reports, presentations, and case discussions in global business contexts	PLO4, PLO5

VI. TEACHING AND LEARNING ACTIVITIES

Teaching & Learning Activities	Expected Contact Hours	Study Load (% of study)
T&L1: Interactive lectures and class discussions	30	25%
T&L2: Lecture preparation and individual assignments	54	45%
T&L3: Group project and final presentation	36	30%
Total	120	100%

VII. ASSESSMENT

Assessment Methods	Weight	Aligned Course Learning Outcomes
A1: Participation	35%	CLO1, 2, 3, 4
A2: Current Topics Paper	15%	CLO1, 2, 3
A3: Group Project	50%	CLO2, 3, 4

A1: Participation (35%)

Pre-class Preparation. This class depends on reading and understanding of the cases and assigned articles, from which we will explore existing theories and develop our own theories. You are expected to have read the assigned materials *before class*. Materials should be read at the level of comprehension at which it is possible to give coherent analyses or be able to ask informed questions. Your careful reading and analysis of the assigned cases is even more important. You should understand fully the situation, the pertinent facts, and the central issues for the case of the session. Your rich experiences and backgrounds should make it possible to consider multiple ideas and examine the issues from a wide variety of perspectives.

In-class Engagement. During class, active engagement is the key. Concepts we cover are subtle and challenging. Being passive will limit your learning while active participation will deepen your knowledge as well as enhance the learning of others. Individual students will also be called randomly to provide their analyses. You should be prepared to lead off the discussion of any question in a significant way as well as to discuss salient issues which are not addressed per se in the assigned questions. You are also expected to listen carefully to others, and build on, critique, or reshape previous ideas from others.

It is the quality of comments, however, not the quantity, that is most germane. Make sure each contribution adds new information and not simply subtracts air time. Occasionally, students find that it is easier to participate effectively from the point of view of a particular person or functional area, or to take on the role of devil's advocate or expert (if expertise is possessed) on the topic. *If you have particular knowledge of any case (e.g., you have worked in the same industry), please let me know in advance.*

In general, four factors determine high-quality comments:

- Is a given comment clearly related to the case and/or topic being discussed?
- Does the comment move the class discussion forward and/or build upon other comments?
- Does the comment reflect consistent and logical reasoning or are there gaps in the logic?
- Does the comment draw on specific facts from the case or personal experience to support the assertion? Note that quality, not quantity, will determine the effectiveness of your comments. "Airtime hogs" will not be rewarded.

As we have a variety of activities planned, participation consists of multiple forms, such as answering questions from the professor and others as well as asking questions, volunteering opinions, describing personal experiences relevant to the issues discussed, contributing other relevant examples, as well as interactions during the Q&A periods with guest speakers.

Attendance. Since so much of the learning occurs in class, there are ***no unapproved absences***. Specifically, any absence requires a written explanation via email that is given to the teaching team prior to class. One miss is fine, but more absences may result in downward adjustment of your grade. *All other MGM attendance policies (if more restrictive) apply.*

Study Groups. I encourage students to meet regularly in study groups to discuss cases before class meets. Working in groups will give you a chance to learn from your colleagues, saving you time from trying to understand the case alone. It also provides an opportunity to discuss ideas in a setting approximating the management teams typically charged with these tasks.

Guest Speakers. We will have guest speakers visiting our class to share their insights related to digital technologies and digital transformation in general. You are encouraged to prepare in advance and submit your questions via Google form (link on Moodle) before their respective visit. Paying close attention to their talks, asking relevant questions, and engaging actively during Q&A will help you gain most from the experience and count toward in-class participation.

A2: Current Topics Paper (15%)

The Digital Strategy Current Topics Paper is aimed to leverage existing concepts and learnings to evaluate an organizational decision related to digital strategy featured in a current event news article and formulate a well-reasoned and supported assessment for the quality of this decision. You will select a current event news article from the Wall Street Journal, New York Times, Financial Times, Business Times, TechCrunch, VentureBeat, and etc., that prominently features an organizational decision or dilemma related to its digital strategy.

You should draw upon theories and concepts from this course (and/or other related courses) to provide a rigorous analysis based on well-supported arguments (not just your opinion). Your paper should address the following questions:

- What was the strategic decision? (Provide short description/summary.)
- Why do you think the organization made this decision? (May not be explicit in article.)
- Was this a good or bad strategic decision and why? (Take a clear stance and argue for it drawing on the theories and concepts from the course.)

Some guidelines and expectations:

- ***Deliverable Format:*** Your Digital Strategy Current Topics paper is submitted via Moodle (two-page max, single- or 1.5-spaced, Times New Roman, 12-point font, 1-inch margins) and due as indicated in the Schedule of Class.
- This is NOT a case summary. Beyond a brief introduction of the business situation, you should avoid devoting a large portion of the paper to descriptions only. Be analytical.
- Focus. Aim for depth rather than breadth. Use this an opportunity to practice effectively illustrating your stance and defending your points.
- Write in prose; we expect a short essay. Articulate the main points clearly using topic sentences and make sure the writing and argumentation flows logically. No bullet lists are to be employed for your paper.

A3: Group Project (50%)

The final component of the course is a group project. The group project provides valuable experience in working with course concepts in the context of the strategy of a real company or business within a larger corporation that is of particular interest to you. The company could be platform-based, adding platform initiatives to existing businesses, transforming its business model into platforms, or actively participating in the platform ecosystems. Taking on the roles of consultants, investment bankers, private equity investors or corporate managers, your group will apply the learned concepts, analytical tools, and frameworks to identify and analyze your chosen company's key strategic challenges or opportunities related to platform management and/or digital transformation, and present a set of recommendations for future strategy.

This project is intentionally somewhat open ended because each company and the issues it faces are unique, and thus you should tailor your analysis accordingly. The choice about the relative weight to put on different concepts and theoretical frameworks in explaining the firm's activities, strategic decisions, issues/opportunities, and derived recommendations is yours. Key deliverables and milestones are as follows.

Group Formation and Proposed Company

This is a list of your group members and your proposed company submitted via Google Form (link on Moodle) due as indicated in Schedule of Class. The teaching team will resolve any duplicate

companies if necessary. The teaching team will announce the updated list of “taken” companies and groups on an on-going basis to facilitate organizing.

Initial Plan

This is a one-page summary (one-page max, single-spaced, Times New Roman, 12-point font, 1-inch margins) of your proposed project that crisply identifies the strategic problems or opportunities of your company, and your preliminary solutions to address the issue (or the value propositions of your proposed initiatives). The document should also outline your plan (and rough timeline) for completing the project including data sources that you expect to use and the people whom you anticipate interviewing (if any). This is due as indicated in Schedule of Class.

Consultation Office Hours (Optional)

During these office hours, I will meet with your group to get to know you better and also help answer any questions your group may have. At the beginning of the meeting, your group may deliver a 2-minute pitch that encapsulates the main ideas in your one-page summary. Consider this as an elevator pitch during a chance encounter with a super angel (unfortunately fictitious money!) Your initial plan and your pitch will enable me to give you constructive feedback and help direct and facilitate your project work. Consultation office hours are optional and will be arranged as indicated in the course syllabus.

Final Paper

The final paper is focused on the current strategy of the business, key strategic challenges or opportunities they are facing related to platform management and/or digital transformation, and your recommendations for future strategy. It should be clearly written, rely on data (e.g., archival and interview data), and be supported by analyses using relevant frameworks from class. The paper will be evaluated based on whether your analyses are well-grounded in concepts relevant to the situation, sufficiently supported by relevant quantitative and qualitative data and/or interview insights, tightly linked to the set of recommendations you propose, as well as presented in a logical, coherent, and clear manner.

The paper should include maximum 20 pages of text, plus exhibits and references (double-spaced, Times New Roman, 12-point font, 1-inch margins). You are allowed to include additional materials (tables, charts, figures) in an appendix that does not count toward the length limit. Please include a one-page executive summary in addition to the main paper (not counting toward the page limit). Your final paper is due on Moodle as indicated in Schedule of Class.

Final Presentation

Each group will prepare a final presentation in the last two sessions. The presentations, including Q&A, should cover the key points of your final paper. Each member of the group should speak roughly equally. Please ensure that your presentation fits into the allotted time as we will not be able to allocate extra time given the size of the class. Presentation slots will be assigned randomly. Your presentation slide decks are due on Moodle as indicated in Schedule of Class.

Peer Evaluation (Needed for a grade)

Please evaluate the performance of your teammates by allocating a performance bonus of \$100,000 (again, unfortunately fictitious money!) among them. The amount of the bonus should reflect each individual's overall contribution to the group's effort, based both on quantity and quality. The expectation is that each team member will contribute equally. So, please handle any conflicts prior to this evaluation. Please speak with the teaching team if problems arise for which you would like advice.

Non-Disclosure Agreements

The teaching team can accommodate the confidentiality requirements of your chosen company. We can sign confidentiality agreements, and work with you to make your presentation suitable for the class in light of any confidentiality restrictions that you might have. Of course, the fewer confidentiality restrictions, the better. Please indicate any restrictions very clearly on the cover page of your paper so that we are not working from memory.

VIII. STANDARDS FOR ASSESSMENT

Course Grade Descriptors

A+, A, A-	Consistently exhibits strong analytical skills and the ability to define, analyze and solve strategic problems by means of the relevant theoretical frameworks and consistently shows original thinking.
B+, B, B-	Frequently exhibits strong analytical skills and the ability to define, analyze and solve strategic problems by means of the relevant theoretical frameworks and shows some original thinking.
C+, C, C-	Only occasionally exhibits strong analytical skills and the ability to define, analyze and solve strategic problems by means of the relevant theoretical framework, showing little evidence of original thinking.
D+, D	Only occasionally exhibits basic analytical skills and the ability to define, analyze and solve strategic problems by means of the relevant theoretical frameworks and lacks original thinking.
F	Unable to define, analyze and solve strategic problems through the relevant theoretical frameworks.

Assessment Rubrics for Participation

A+, A, A-	• Consistently participated voluntarily in case discussions and other class discussions. • All or almost all contributions to the discussion are relevant, clear, well-articulated and insightful and consist of relevant and helpful examples and analyses, creative and insightful solutions, thereby appropriately challenging assumptions and perspectives, showing outstanding ability to apply theory and concepts to practical examples.
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B+, B, B-	- Consistently participated voluntarily in case discussions and other class discussions. - Most contributions to the discussion are relevant, clear, well-articulated and insightful and consist of relevant and helpful examples and analyses, creative and insightful solutions, thereby appropriately challenging assumptions and perspectives, showing strong ability to apply theory and concepts to practical examples.
C+, C, C-	- Occasionally participated voluntarily in case discussions and other class discussions. - Some contributions to the discussion are relevant, clear, well-articulated and insightful and consist of relevant and helpful examples and analyses, showing some creative and insightful solutions, thereby showing moderate ability to apply theory and concepts to practical examples.
D+, D	- Occasionally participated voluntarily in case discussions and other class discussions. - Few contributions to the discussion are relevant, clear, well-articulated and insightful and consist of limited relevant and helpful examples and analyses, showing very limited creative and insightful solutions, thereby showing very limited ability to apply theory and concepts to practical examples.
F	Failed to participate voluntarily or simply recited comments made by others.

Assessment Rubrics for Current Topics Paper

A+, A, A-	- All or almost all of the questions are clearly and accurately answered showing outstanding insights into the theoretical material and an outstanding ability to conduct case analysis and apply concepts and theory. - All or almost all of the responses are well organized, clear, fluent, and with sufficient elaboration.
B+, B, B-	- Most of the questions are clearly and accurately answered showing good insights into the theoretical material and a strong ability to conduct case analysis and apply concepts and theory. - Most of the responses are well organized, clear, fluent, and with sufficient elaboration.
C+, C, C-	- Some of the questions are clearly and accurately answered showing good insights into the theoretical material and a strong ability to conduct case analysis and apply concepts and theory. - Some of the responses are well organized, clear, fluent, and with sufficient elaboration.
D+, D	- Few of the questions are clearly and accurately answered showing good insights into the theoretical material and a strong ability to conduct case analysis and apply concepts and theory. - Few of the responses are well organized, clear, fluent, and with sufficient elaboration.

F	• Very few or none of the questions are clearly and accurately answered showing good insights into the theoretical material and a strong ability to conduct case analysis and apply concepts and theory. • Very few or none of the responses are well organized, clear, fluent, and with sufficient elaboration.
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Assessment Rubrics for Group Project

A+, A, A-	<u>Analysis and application of theory:</u> • Demonstrates an outstanding understanding of, and the ability to apply theory and concepts to the case company chosen. • All relevant aspects about the company were addressed and researched in sufficient depth. • Draws widely from relevant sources and cites sources correctly. <u>Recommendations:</u> • Outstanding ability to adopt a critical perspective and provide adequate, feasible and creative strategy formulation and execution. • Recommendation(s) follow logically from analysis. <u>Writing and Structure:</u> • Logical structure of presentation/paper as a whole. • Excellent development of arguments and offers a logically consistent and well-articulated analysis and insight into the subject. • No spelling or grammar mistakes.
B+, B, B-	<u>Analysis and application of theory:</u> • Demonstrates a good understanding of, and the ability to apply theory and concepts to the case company chosen. • Most relevant aspects about the case company were addressed and researched in sufficient depth. • Draws widely from relevant sources and cites sources correctly. <u>Recommendations:</u> • Mediocre ability to adopt a critical perspective and provide adequate, feasible and creative strategy formulation and execution. • Recommendation(s) follow logically from analysis. <u>Writing and Structure:</u> • Logical structure of presentation/paper as a whole. • Good development of arguments and offers a logically consistent and well-articulated analysis and insight into the subject. • No spelling or grammar mistakes.
C+, C, C-	<u>Analysis and application of theory:</u> • Demonstrates limited understanding of, and the ability to apply theory and concepts to the case company chosen. • Some relevant aspects about the case company were addressed and researched in depth. • Limited use of sources of information but correct citation of sources. <u>Recommendations:</u>

	• Good ability to adopt a critical perspective and provide adequate, feasible and creative strategy formulation and execution. • Recommendation(s) follow logically from analysis. <u>Writing and Structure:</u> • Flaws in the logic of the structure of presentation/paper as a whole. • Mediocre development of arguments offering limited insight into the subject. • No spelling or grammar mistakes.
D+, D	<u>Analysis and application of theory:</u> • Demonstrates a minimum understanding of, and the ability to apply theory and concepts to the case company chosen. • Relevant aspects about the case company were not addressed. <u>Recommendations:</u> • Limited ability to adopt a critical perspective and provide adequate, feasible and creative strategy formulation and execution. • Recommendation(s) are made in a marginally accepted manner. <u>Writing and Structure:</u> • Flaws in the logic of the arguments and the structure of the paper. • Meet a standard of marginally acceptable performance in the assessments with some errors in writing.
F	<u>Analysis and application of theory:</u> • Demonstrates lack of understanding of, and the ability to apply theory and concepts to the case company chosen. • Relevant aspects about the case company were not addressed. <u>Recommendations:</u> • Inability to adopt a critical perspective and provide adequate, feasible and creative strategy formulation and execution. • Recommendation(s) do not follow logically from the analysis. <u>Writing and Structure:</u> • Flaws in the logic of the arguments and the structure of the paper. • Failure to use available software for grammar and spelling checks, resulting in poor writing, typos and grammatical errors.

IX. ACADEMIC AND CLASS CONDUCT

Simple rule regarding plagiarism: **don't do it**. The University regulations on academic dishonesty are strictly enforced. Please check the [University Statement on plagiarism](#).

The University regulations regarding intellectual property are also strictly enforced. **You are not to copy, post, share, or reproduce any class materials including recordings, lecture slides, case readings and handouts without the written consent of the teaching team.**

We encourage everyone to actively participate in course activities, both inside and outside the classroom, but want to emphasize that individual privacy should be fully respected and not to be violated. The goal is for all of us to collectively create one productive and inclusive environment that is psychologically safe and engaging in order to foster the best learning outcomes possible.

AI Use Policy

We recognize that AI tools are becoming integral to professional practice. The following policy governs AI use in this course:

Permitted Uses

- Using AI to brainstorm ideas and explore different perspectives
- Using AI to help understand complex concepts or frameworks
- Using AI for grammar checking, proofreading, or improving writing clarity
- Using AI to help with research by identifying relevant sources or summarizing background information
- Experimenting with AI tools as part of understanding AI capabilities

Prohibited Uses

- Submitting AI-generated content as your own original work, even partially, without original intellectual contribution, critical evaluation, or substantial transformation, is strictly prohibited.
- Using AI for class participation is strictly prohibited unless explicitly permitted by the teaching team for specific learning activities.

Transparency and Attribution

- Disclose all AI tool usage in a brief statement appended to your submission specifying which AI tools were used, for which purposes, and how they were used and built upon.
- *Retain and be prepared to submit your AI conversation logs related to class assignments upon request.*
- Understand that you remain fully responsible for the accuracy, quality, and originality of all submitted work.

Guiding Principle

Think of AI as a tool that can enhance your productivity and learning, similar to calculators or search engines. The goal is to use AI in ways that help you learn more effectively and produce better work, not to shortcut the learning process. Your development as a strategic thinker (the ability to analyze situations, apply frameworks, and generate insights) remains the core objective. The ability to critically evaluate AI-generated content and add genuine analytical value is itself a skill this course aims to develop.

X. MEANS/PROCESSES FOR STUDENT FEEDBACK ON COURSE

HKU places significant importance on student learning and on the continuous enhancement of teaching and learning outcomes. You are encouraged to provide feedback to me via various channels throughout the module. Access to an evaluation questionnaire will also be provided at the end of the course. Your comments and feedback are greatly valued and appreciated.

XI. COURSE CONTENT AND TEACHING SCHEDULE

SCHEDULE OF CLASSES

*Note: Subject to change**

WEEK ONE

Session 1. Introduction: Platform Revolution and the AI Frontier

Optional	Digital Ubiquity: How Connections, Sensors, and Data Are Revolutionizing Business AI Index Report 2025 (Stanford HAI)
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Session 2. Open Innovation and Community-Driven Business Model

Reading	Using Open Innovation to Identify the Best Ideas
Case	Threadless (multimedia)
Optional	Open Innovation in the Age of AI Using the Crowd as an Innovation Partner

Group information due by 5pm Wednesday February 4th, 2026

WEEK TWO

Session 3. Value Creation: Platform Foundation and Launch

Reading	Pipelines, Platforms, and the New Rules of Strategy How to Launch Your Digital Platform
Case	Airbnb, Etsy, Uber: Acquiring the First 1K Customers

Session 4. Value Creation: From Product to Platform

Reading	Finding the Platform in Your Product Do You Really Want to be an eBay
Case	Intuit QuickBooks

Group Project Initial Plan due by 5pm Wednesday February 11th, 2026

**No class during Week Three and Week Four given CNY holiday; use these weeks to work on group project and case study questions.*

WEEK FIVE

Session 5. Value Capture: Platform Monetization and Beyond

Reading	Strategies for Two-Sided Markets Network Effects aren't Enough
Case	Videogames: Clouds on the Horizon? Airbnb, Etsy, Uber: Growing from 1K to 1M Customers
Optional	Why Some Platforms Thrive and Others Don't

Session 6. Competition in the Age of Digital Platforms

Reading	Competing on Platforms
Case	X Fire Paintball & Airsoft: is Amazon a Friend or Foe?
Optional	What's Your Google Strategy?

Current Topics Paper due by 5pm Wednesday March 4th, 2026

WEEK SIX

Session 7. Data Analytics, AI, and Digital Transformation

Reading	Discovery-Driven Digital Transformation The Gen AI Playbook for Organizations
Guest Speaker	Mr. Rick DUAN, Senior Partner Solution Sales (AI Business Solutions), Microsoft China
Optional	Competing on Analytics

Session 8. Digital Experimentation and AI-Enhanced Decision Making

Reading	How to Design Smart Business Experiments The Surprising Power of Online Experiments
Activity	Experimentation Workshop

WEEK SEVEN

Session 9. Group Project Presentations

Group Project Presentation (for some groups) due

Note Some groups (randomly selected and notified in advance) will make their PowerPoint presentations in Session 9. Remaining groups will make their PowerPoint presentations in Session 10.

Session 10. Group Project Presentations + Synthesis

Note ***Group Project Presentation (for remaining groups) and
Peer Evaluation Form (for all groups) due***

Final Paper due by 5pm Wednesday March 18th, 2026

Peer Evaluation Form due by 5pm Wednesday March 18th, 2026